

Dehydration & ORS: rehydrate early, know danger signs

Dehydration can become dangerous fast. Babies, young children, older adults, and people who are ill are at higher risk. **Oral rehydration solution (ORS)** replaces water and salts. It works better than plain water when dehydration risk is high.

SEEK URGENT MEDICAL HELP NOW

Get urgent help if the person is very drowsy, confused, unconscious, or has a seizure. Also get help if they cannot drink, cannot keep fluids down, vomit again and again, have blood in stool, have severe belly pain, show signs of severe dehydration, are a very young infant, or keep getting worse despite rehydration. Use local emergency services when needed.

Use packaged ORS if available

Use commercially prepared ORS packets when you can. Mix exactly as the packet says. Use safe water and the full amount of water listed. Too little water can make the drink too salty. Too much water can make it work less well.

If no packet is available: emergency home mix

MEASURE CAREFULLY

Only use a home mix when packaged ORS is not available and you can measure carefully.

- 1 liter safe water
- 6 level teaspoons sugar
- 1/2 level teaspoon salt

Stir until the sugar and salt dissolve. The drink should taste no saltier than tears. If it tastes very salty, throw it away and mix again. Throw it away after 24 hours, or sooner if it gets dirty.

How to give fluids

- Give small, frequent sips. If vomiting occurs, wait 5–10 minutes and try again slowly.
- For infants and young children, use a spoon, cup, or syringe in small amounts often.
- Continue breastfeeding and normal age-appropriate feeding when possible.
- Do not give fluids by mouth to someone who is unconscious, very confused, unable to swallow safely, or having a seizure.
- Avoid alcohol. Avoid very sugary drinks as the main rehydration fluid during diarrhea; they can worsen diarrhea for some people.

For children: also give zinc

RECOMMENDED BY WHO & UNICEF

For a child with diarrhea, WHO and UNICEF recommend **zinc every day for 10–14 days**, along with ORS. Zinc can shorten the illness. It can also make it less severe and help prevent diarrhea in the following months. The usual amount is **20 mg per day** for children. For infants under 6 months, the usual amount is **10 mg per day**. Use a zinc product made for children. Follow the package or a health worker's instructions. Keep giving zinc for the full course, even after diarrhea stops.

Watch for dehydration

CONCERNING SIGNS

- Very thirsty, dry mouth, little or no urination
- Dizziness, weakness, fast heartbeat
- Sunken eyes, no tears in a child, unusual sleepiness
- Persistent diarrhea or vomiting

EMERGENCY SIGNS

- Very drowsy, confused, limp, or unconscious
- Unable to drink or breastfeed
- Repeated vomiting or signs getting worse
- Blood in stool, severe pain, or seizure

For caregivers and volunteers

- Ask the person's age and symptoms. Ask if they can drink, how often they urinate, how often they vomit or have diarrhea, and whether there is blood.
- Prioritize urgent care for babies, older adults, pregnant people, people with chronic illness, and anyone getting worse.
- Do not diagnose the cause of diarrhea or vomiting. Help with safe fluids and escalation.
- Use safe water. If you are not sure the water is safe, follow local guidance. You may need to boil it, treat it, or use sealed water.

Prevent the next illness

- **Wash hands with soap** after using the toilet or cleaning a child. Wash before preparing food or eating.
- **Use safe drinking water.** Store it covered and clean. Boil or treat water when you are not sure it is safe.
- **Use a toilet or latrine** and dispose of stool, including children's, safely.
- **Vaccinate:** the rotavirus vaccine protects babies against a common, severe cause of diarrhea. Ask your health service.

Sources

- World Health Organization (WHO) — diarrhoeal disease and oral rehydration guidance.
- UNICEF — diarrhoeal disease and oral rehydration resources. [unicef.org](https://www.unicef.org)

- WHO/UNICEF — joint statement on clinical management of acute diarrhoea, including ORS and zinc.
- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — diarrheal illness prevention and dehydration-related guidance.
- MedlinePlus / U.S. National Library of Medicine — dehydration information.

This guide is general information, not medical advice. It is not a substitute for professional care. Local guidance may differ, especially for infants, cholera outbreaks, severe malnutrition, kidney or heart disease, or other medical conditions. When in doubt, seek medical help.